Two Brothers: A Fiction

By Ai

INTRODUCTION

Why did Robert Kennedy court his brother's fate by seeking the Presidency after incurring the enmity of the same criminal and political underworlds that, most people now believe, precipitated his older brother's murder? It is documented fact that Robert Kennedy ordered that autopsy materials remaining from investigations into his brother's death be handed over to his staff. This included a stainless steel container that held President Kennedy's brain, which subsequently vanished.

"Two Brothers" by Ai is a dramatic poem spoken by Jack Kennedy, five years after his death, in the Los Angeles Ambassador Hotel room of his brother, just as Bobby comes out of a dreaming sleep before making his victory speech in the pivotal California Democratic Presidential Primary on the night of June 4, 1968. After midnight that same night, as Bobby Kennedy walked off-stage through the hotel kitchen area, he would, too, be assassinated as he paused to shake hands with well-wishing kitchen staff. Now, however, Bobby prepares to assume his dead brother's destiny.

Two Brothers by Ai

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1

Night tightens its noose.
You swim toward me out of sleep
like an eel,
as I put the glass canister
beside you on the bed.
Death, Bobby, hit me
like the flat of a hand.
Imagine you are made of crystal
and someone ice picks you
and you shatter,
all your cells coming
almost to despair
it is so good. Dallas. Dallas.
I turn toward the window,
then turn back to you.
Remember that Crayola drawing
of John-John's? --
the black smoke coming out the roof
of the White House
like curly black hair.

How Jackie spanked his hand
and drew him another
with angels lifting up?
Our own childhoods? --
days of ease and grace.
The good life sucking us deeper
and deeper in
toward its hot, liquid center,
where seasoned with the right diction,
schools, and politics
we would fry crisp and greaseless.
King for a day,
that's who I was.
I drove power,
the solid-gold Cadillac.
Go ahead, frown.
Tell me about the sin of pride
and I'll tell you
about the lie of forgiveness.
It wasn't Oswald killed me,
it was envy.

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2

"I have this dream, Jack," you say.
"I'm at Arlington. It's twilight.
Thousands of funeral markers
rise from the ground
like dirty alabaster arms.
It's here, pilgrim,
they seem to say.
And then I'm in a room.
A man is counting green bills
Sharp enough to cut,
while I pry the lid off a barrel
and peer down into it,
As if inside, there are dark green pickles
or steel-blue fish,
as if I were a boy
on a crowded street in Russia
with my hand around a coin
and the other in my brother's hand>
And while I scuff my shoe
and try to decide,

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from far away I hear bugles, hoofbeats,
I see my brother's head
suddenly rise from his body
like a tiny pink ball
on a spout of dark red water,
clear past the rooftops
into the serene evening sky.
I am that boy, Jack,
dipping his hands
in the one standing barrel,
Into water warm as blood,
with nothing to say to anybody,
except, 'My brother is the moon.'"

3

Riddles, I say,
lifting the lid off the canister.
I pull out a wet, gray mass,
stare at it, then put it back.
Some African tribes
eat the brains of their dead.

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It brings them closer;
it kills them too.
But whatever it takes, Bobby, right?
I look out the window
at the deep rose welts of dawn,
streaking the sky's broad back,
Then hand you the canister.
You lift out my brain.
When you bit down, I burn.
The air smells like creosote
and I stand before you,
my skin plum and pink,
my wounds healed.
I put my arms around you
and you disappear into me . . .

I stare at myself in the mirror:
Jack Kennedy,
thinner now, almost ascetic,
wearing the exhaust fumes of L.A.
like a sharkskin suit,

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while the quarter moon

hangs from heaven,

a swing on a gold chain. My throne.

I step back and knot my tie.

Bobby, it's all a matter of showmanship.

You have to have the ability to entertain,

to stand like P.T. Barnum

in the enchanted center

of the public eye,

to drop your pants now and then

and have the crowd

cry for more,

to give it to them,

to take those encores,

till like the clown in Piaf's song

the show is all there is,

and the bravos, the bravos.

You give the people what they want, Bobby,

Someone they can't help loving

like a father or an uncle,

someone who through his own magical fall

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lifts them above the slime

of their daily lives.

Not God made man,

but man made God.

I step back to the mirror.

Break a leg, kid, I say to myself.

Give 'em a miracle,

Give 'em Hollywood.

Give 'em Saint Jack.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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NOTE: An analysis of this poem to aid in the student's understanding and interpretation can be found at http://oldrpo.library.utoronto.ca/poem/3359.html

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